

Bill's Life Principles– 2014

When you've lived 75 years, one comes to the realization that the end is closer than the beginning. I'm just coming to that realization, though I am not changing my ways...merely musing a bit.

Everybody develops their own "life principles" that guide their decisions in life. These are some of mine, and in reading them, one may understand more of my thoughts and actions.

We all want to make a difference in the world. If you find some wisdom or guidance in your life from my thoughts...good for all.

I'm having a "great ride" in life and hopefully these thoughts explain some of my actions...particularly since the Reynolds side of the family has the reputation of being tight-lipped.

- Altruism – Altruism feels good, and may help some, but it does not positively change people's behavior, and often creates dependency.
- "Earn" your life rewards. Those that are just given do not give you the "AHA!" moments that sustain you. The "entitlement attitude" our country is fostering does not lead to happy and sustainable feelings.
- Free Market Capitalism - Sets America apart from the rest of the world. Understanding this basic principle will help shape one's response to life's setbacks. We all must compete in life and in true competition, winners and losers. I've been both but learned more when I've lost because it forced me to change.
- Property Rights are Human Rights – A fundamental requirement of a capitalist economic system is a strong system of property rights. Social critics often complain that property rights take precedence over "human" rights. I believe that strong legally protected property rights protect individual liberty. Any restraint/abolishment of these individual rights is a move toward government control.
- "Helping others" not only makes one feel worthwhile, but one learns something from everyone.
- Integrity is built over a lifetime. One definition is, "do what you say". Integrity is about your values and following those values in your decisions shapes your behavior. What do you do when no one is around to observe your actions?
- Life experiences almost always involve negotiation. Learn how and practice this skill. Young children are always pushing the limits. Don't be afraid to "ask for the order" early and often.
- Successful life strategies involve being a "good salesman". Practice and understand the basic principles. I've always used "listening and questions" as a basic strategy.

- Physical exercise – I’ve always done my best creative thinking on long runs and bikes by myself, where my mind just wanders.
- Seek diversity with your friends and activities. You can always learn by looking at the diverse opinions from smart people.
- Life’s “Walls” – Throughout life, one hits many of these “walls” when at the time it seems unbearable, but how one reacts makes us who we are. Tough times and events occur throughout life... Learn from them; it’s how you react to those events that make us strong and confident. Be persistent.
- Risk – Life always has many paths to follow. I couldn’t imagine going through life without the challenges and rewards that come by taking “calculated” risks. Nobody bats “100%” and your first loss is your best loss.
- Contacts – who you know. Successful people have a myriad of contacts both direct and indirect, so they can talk to decision makers whenever they need to.
- As I age, family and friends become more important. Cultivate and maintain relationships with many.
- Personal Responsibility (if it is to be, it is up to me)– You alone have in your power the ability to set the path for your life. Too often we veer “off course” and blame others (see excuses below):
 - “What can I do about it?” Impotence/Helplessness
 - “I didn’t start this.” Innocence
 - “Everyone else is doing it.” The herd
 - “I’m just looking out for myself.” Survival
 - “God told me to.” Appeal to higher authority
 - “I couldn’t help it, I was afraid.” Appeal to emotions
- True knowledge likes disorder. Innovation gains from uncertainty. Disorder/perturbation in life should be welcomed. You will be wiser and make better decisions if you can use these “uncomfortable”/“out of comfort zone” times to better your decisions. (See Taleb book, “Antifragile”)
- Money/wealth/happiness – Money may make life easier, however it does not bring happiness. Happiness must come from your own earned credits.
- Decision periods – In life’s constant and alternating series of “punches to the gut” (failures and criticism), and “pats on the back” (success and praise), I’ve made most of my worst decisions when the times were the best (lots of success and praise).

- Group Think – Popular opinion, politically correct thinking is always the “easy way” to make decisions. The outliers of this process are the people that change the world.

“Quotes and Words of Wisdom from others I treasure”

“Weasel Words”, “Square Deal” – Theodore Roosevelt

- “In any moment of decision, the best thing you can do is the right thing, the next best thing is the wrong thing, and the worst thing you can do is NOTHING.”

Socialism – Theodore Roosevelt

- “Socialism is a philosophy of failure; a Gospel of envy; a creed of ignorance; its only inherent value is the equal sharing of misery.”

Self worth – Eleanor Roosevelt

- “Nobody can make you feel inferior without your consent.”

Change – Eric Hofer

- “In times of rapid change, the learners inherit the world while the ‘knowers’ find themselves beautifully equipped to deal with a world that no longer exists.”

Certainty – Eric Hofer

- “We can be absolutely certain only about things we do not understand.”

Capitalism – Ayn Rand

- “Capitalism is the only moral social system because it protects the smallest minority on earth – the individual.”

Envy – Nina Gruen

- “Envy has long been one of humankind’s least admirable traits, and runs counter to happiness. Each of us will always be able to find others who are smarter, better looking, more prominent, or richer than we are. So it will always be.”

Humor—Patty Limerick

- “A robust sense of humor is the foundation of resilience: turning difficult experiences into funny stories provides the bedrock for a long and worthwhile life.”

Optimism—Peter Theil

- “Definite Optimist—A person who believes the future will be better (than the present), and works to make it better.”
- “Indefinite Optimist—Believes the future will be better, but doesn’t know how so he won’t make any plans (this is predominate in America today).”

" Quotes on My Wall"

It is not the critic who counts – Theodore Roosevelt

- Not the man who points out how the strong man stumbled, or where the doer of deeds could have done them better. The credit belongs to the man who is actually in the arena, whose face is marred by dust and sweat and blood; who strives valiantly; who errs, and comes short again and again, because there is no effort without error and shortcoming; but who does actually strive to do the deeds; who knows the great enthusiasms, the great devotions; who spends himself in a worthy cause; who at the best knows in the end the triumph of high achievement, and who at the worst, if he fails, at least fails while daring greatly, so that his place shall never be with those cold and timid souls who know neither victory nor defeat.

My Creed – Dean Alfange

- I do not choose to be a common man. It is my right to be uncommon—if I can. I seek opportunity—not security. I do not wish to be a kept citizen, humbled and dulled by having the state look after me.

I want to take the calculated risk; to dream and to build, to fail and to succeed.

I refuse to barter incentive for a dole. I prefer the challenges of life to the guaranteed existence; the thrill of fulfillment to the state calm of utopia.

I will not trade freedom for beneficence nor my dignity for a handout. I will never cower before any master nor bend to any threat.

It is my heritage to stand erect, proud and unafraid; to think and act for myself, enjoy the benefit of my creations and to face the world boldly and say, this I have done.

All this is what it means to be an American.